

Inside the collapse of Kallas' defense group

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【メール原文】

Presented by Connect Europe By NICHOLAS VINOCUR GREETINGS. It's Nick Vinocur. In today's Playbook: — Ireland is quizzing EU states about the EU budget

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GREETINGS. It's Nick Vinocur.

In today's Playbook:

- Ireland is quizzing EU states about the EU budget. We've got exclusive details.
- The latest PISA student assessment results are in — and they're not good for Europe.
- Faces in the crowd: Ursula von der Leyen, Guido Crosetto, Anders Fogh Rasmussen, Kajsa Ollongren, António Costa, Kristalina Georgieva, Roxana Mînzatu, Nathalie Moll, Maroš Šefčovič, Juan Jesús Vivas, Gavin Newsom and more ...

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Ian unpack how Kaja Kallas' grand EU defense brain trust spectacularly imploded before launch, amid fire, fury and turf wars.

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****A message from Connect Europe: It took 6 days for AI agents to trigger one of the worst cyberattacks to date, while 729 days after Draghi's Report launch only a fraction of his recommendations have been implemented. Alessandro Gropelli argues we should speed up reforms to win the AI race. ****

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DRIVING THE DAY

WHY KALLAS' DEFENSE GROUP FELL APART: Kaja Kallas' plans to launch an expert EU defense group collapsed after Rome and other capitals accused her team of failing to consult governments and warned it risked clashing with NATO, according to four EU diplomats who spoke to Playbook and Jacopo Barigazzi.

The cancellation — announced less than 48 hours before the group's planned launch — is a fresh setback for the bloc's top diplomat, who is already locked in a turf war with Ursula von der Leyen's European Commission over EU foreign policy as the bloc confronts a rising Russian threat and American pullback. It also puts Kallas at odds with the capitals that are supposed to be her main constituency.

Look closer: The launch had been billed as a high-profile event, with invites sent out weeks earlier. But several countries, particularly Italy, said they hadn't been given enough information about the group or its mandate, the diplomats said. The diplomats were granted anonymity to discuss confidential talks.

Not enough: Kallas briefed EU defense ministers on the plan during opening remarks at a meeting in Ireland last week. But that wasn't considered sufficient — partly because some countries had sent lower-ranking officials to the gathering. "There was no proper discussion of this" at either the defense or foreign affairs ministers' meetings, said one diplomat. "Hence, surprise and a bit of annoyance."

Furious: Italian Defense Minister Guido Crosetto "led the charge" against the initiative and was "really upset" that Roberta Pinotti, a former Italian defense minister, had been selected for the group without his knowledge, another diplomat said.

The objection: An Italian official said in a statement shared with Jacopo that several ministers raised "strong concerns" about the initiative directly with Kallas, on the grounds of "both method and substance." Over the weekend, several countries prepared a letter urging the high representative to cancel the launch and submit it for consideration at an upcoming gathering, but the letter was dropped when the event was called off.

99 problems: Other issues with the group included the lack of representation for several countries as well as the Commission, according to the diplomats. Officials also said it risked overlapping with existing policy work, including that of NATO, and the EU security strategy being co-drafted by the Commission and Kallas' European External Action Service.

No way out: A flurry of exchanges between national diplomats over the weekend led to the conclusion that there was "no soft landing zone" for the initiative, said another diplomat.

It's over: The group won't be resurrected, one senior EU official told Jacopo. A report on the future of EU defense policy by former NATO chief Anders Fogh Rasmussen, who was set to lead the group, has also been shelved.

Disappointed: "The Ukrainian government was celebrating the creation of this group," a senior Ukrainian government official told POLITICO's Veronika Melkozerova.

The bottom line: The episode lays bare the deepening splits around who gets to call the shots on the EU's foreign policy — and marks a rough start for new EEAS Secretary-General Kajsa Ollongren, who began her role last week.

BIG AND BREAKING

MERZ ON THE ROPES: Germany's far right is cranking up the pressure on Friedrich Merz after its breakthrough in Saxony-Anhalt — but the stunned chancellor doesn't seem to have a clear plan to save himself or his government, my colleagues in Berlin report.

TRADE SCOOP: Trade Commissioner Maroš Šefčovič will meet European CEOs on Sept. 18 to discuss the EU executive's push to diversify critical supply chains away from China.

CRACKDOWN ON SHORT-TERM RENTALS: Brussels is preparing to give cities and regions new powers to rein in short-term rentals as part of its upcoming Affordable Housing Act, due to be approved Wednesday, Aitor Hernández-Morales reports.

GROUP CHAIR ELECTIONS: The EPP, Socialists and Democrats and Renew are considering bringing forward their chair and vice chair elections to October to match the Greens and give them a stronger hand in January's top jobs reshuffle, four officials told Max Grier.

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MONEY, MONEY, MONEY

IRELAND'S TAX QUESTIONNAIRE: The Irish Council presidency asked the 27 EU ambassadors to make clear how much money they want to generate for the seven-year budget through EU-wide taxes. "What is a realistic acceptable volume for the Own Resources package to generate?" it asked in the note , seen by Playbook.

France vs. the rest: Ireland wants to achieve progress on the issue during a meeting of EU ambassadors today. France insists that new levies are key to generating more revenue and reducing national contributions to Brussels. But most governments have misgivings about the specific ideas on the table.

Pick your tax: Ireland also asked EU envoys to suggest changes to the Commission's proposed new taxes. It welcomed "consensus" among governments to introduce new levies on foreign polluters and electronic waste. They could generate €1.64 billion and €17.9 billion per year on average from 2028-2034. But that's unlikely to be enough for France.

COSTA'S TAX TOUR: EU taxes will be at the heart of discussions as European Council President António Costa's "Tour des Capitales" takes him to Berlin, Warsaw and Madrid in the coming days, my colleagues Zoya Sheftalovich and Gregorio Sorgi write. The most politically fraught stop will be Berlin on Wednesday, where Friedrich Merz will be under pressure to take an even harder line on the bloc's long-term budget after the AfD's election victory on Sunday.

UKRAINE MONEY WORRIES: The EU doesn't just have to worry about paying its own bills — it's also got to think about Ukraine. Today, the IMF may provide some help.

Mind the gap: Kyiv recently put its defense-budget shortfall at \$27 billion. But Brussels is working with Volodymyr Zelenskyy's government on financing for 2026 and 2027, including access to a €90 billion EU loan.

First things first: "What you need to do first is to get a clear picture of what the budgetary or financial situation is," Commission spokesperson Balázs Ujvári said. Only then can Brussels look at "ways of addressing it."

Valdis on the case: Economy Commissioner Valdis Dombrovskis spoke Monday with Ukrainian Prime Minister Serhii Koryukha about Kyiv's financing needs. Dombrovskis will today meet IMF chief Kristalina Georgieva, with Ukraine on the agenda.

Why it matters: The IMF's forecasts are crucial for Brussels' calculations. But the IMF's overview of Ukraine's needs is based on the assumption that the war ends this year — a prospect few expect to materialize.

Enlargement pays: The IMF will also today unveil a report, seen by POLITICO, on the economic gains from enlargement for candidates and existing members, focusing on the Western Balkans and Moldova.

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

There are two meetings of the Political and Security Committee in Brussels this week (and most weeks) ... but what does that committee do? Its job is to discuss how world events affect the EU's Common Foreign and Security Policy and recommend strategies to the Council. The PSC's members are ambassador-level officials, one from each member state, based in Brussels, and it is chaired by a representative of Kaja Kallas, the EU foreign policy chief.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

EU'S PISA FAIL

BAD REPORT CARD: European countries generally scored poorly on the OECD's PISA test, which is held every three years worldwide and judges 15-year-olds' math, reading and science skills, a European official with knowledge of the results coming out today told Playbook.

Best and worst in class: Estonian and Irish pupils scored highly across all three categories in the last test in 2022, while those from Bulgaria, Romania, Cyprus and Greece fared the worst.

Good timing? European Commission Vice President Roxana Mînzatu will unveil the EU's education package in November, in a bid to address declining performance levels in schools.

Join us online today, Sept. 8, at 4 p.m. CEST for an exclusive analysis of Germany's far right challenge. POLITICO's James Angelos and Nette Nöstlinger will examine the AfD's historic result in Saxony-Anhalt, its path to power and what the election means for Chancellor Friedrich Merz's government. Register here .

4 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

MIGRATION RETHINK: Images of migrants flooding the beaches of Ceuta — and the ensuing political crisis — are forcing migration-rights organizations to reconsider how they make their cases .

THE CORN GAP: Europe is suddenly short of corn ... Ukraine desperately wants to get its grain to market ... but American farmers thousands of kilometers away may be best-placed to cash in, Bartosz Brzeziński reports.

RUNNING OUT OF TIME: The Commission plans to rework public procurement to favor clean-tech producers from the bloc, but solar bosses say they need help now — before more factories disappear.

THE LEAST FREE PLACE ON EARTH: Residents of Russia-occupied Ukraine have no political rights, freedom of expression or protection from secret detention, Lily Hyde writes.

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Sunny intervals, changing to cloud and rain in the afternoon. High of 22C.

RAT ATTACK: The end of Brussels' summer heat wave is causing an explosion in the number of rats scurrying around the streets, and officials are scrambling to contain it . Local government authorities are asking residents not to throw out heaps of edible trash in their waste bags.

"Some people throw whole loaves of bread or pizzas out, others their leftover fast-food meals," municipal spokesperson Andreas De Kerpel told VRT. "For rats, it's all a feast." But the city's notorious refusal to adopt domestic waste bins means some residents have little choice.

HOSPITALIZED: Former European Commissioner and Italian Foreign Minister Emma Bonino was admitted to hospital in Rome yesterday after experiencing respiratory problems, La Repubblica reported. She was said to be in serious condition but alert and responding to treatment.

SPOTTED ... at pharma lobby group EFPIA's rooftop soirée at the Residence Palace, where any grumbles about the early end time were swiftly abated by the top-notch daiquiris and "Bridgerton"-style violins and wisteria: EFPIA's Director-General Nathalie Moll; EUCOPE senior adviser Matthias Heck; DG GROW's Thomas Heynisch; Vaccines Europe Executive Director Sibilila Quilici; Sanofi's Nicolas Obrist; EuropaBio Director-General Claire Skentelbery; European Patients' Forum Executive Director Valentina Strammiello; Cypriot attaché Loukas Georgiou; an exquisitely-suited Davidson Leite of MedTech Europe; and POLITICO's Emma Krstic, Mari Eccles and Claudia Chiappa.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Reeling from Saxony-Anhalt, Friedrich Merz's coalition is split over whether to speed up its reform plans or reverse some of the measures it has already announced.

Paris: Sébastien Lecornu is scrambling to contain the fallout from a budget leak suggesting the government could hike taxes on workplace savings plans.

London: Foreign Secretary Ed Miliband will announce a sharp shift in Britain's stance toward Israel , with new sanctions on trade with settlements.

Washington: California Governor Gavin Newsom is pitching himself as a consensus-builder as he keeps the door open to a bid for the Democratic presidential nomination.

Canberra: While Labor's "digital duty of care" sparks debate about government censorship, officials say politicians posting clips of parliamentary committee hearings is exposing them to harassment and abuse.

AGENDA

- European Council President António Costa meets EPP President Manfred Weber.
- EU High Representative Kaja Kallas meets Lithuanian Foreign Minister Kęstutis Budrys, Defense Minister Robertas Kaunas and Seimas Speaker Juozas Olekas in Vilnius, and speaks at the annual meeting of Lithuanian diplomatic missions.
- Migration Commissioner Magnus Brunner and Mediterranean Commissioner Dubravka Šuica meet Ceuta's Mayor-President Juan Jesús Vivas in Brussels.
- Trade Commissioner Maroš Šefčovič meets German Foreign Minister Johann Wadephul and Economic Affairs and Energy Minister Katherina Reiche in Berlin.
- Economy Commissioner Valdis Dombrovskis meets IMF Managing Director Kristalina Georgieva.
- Coreper II meets at 10 a.m.
- Informal meeting of agriculture ministers in Dublin. Press conference at 2 p.m. Watch .
- Šuica meets Spanish Foreign Minister José Manuel Albares ... and International Organization for Migration Director-General Amy Pope.
- Defense Commissioner Andrius Kubilius participates in the 36th Ukraine Defence Contact Group meeting via videoconference.
- International Partnerships Commissioner Jozef Síkela receives European Investment Bank President Nadia Calviño.

BIRTHDAYS

MEP Veronika Vrecionová; Aurel Trandafir of the Committee of the Regions; Claire Froitzheim from the U.K. Competition and Markets Authority; former Council of Europe Commissioner for Human Rights Dunja Mijatović; Eerik-Niiles Kross, Estonian politician and POLITICO 28 alum; Hefercé's Frédéric Cornet. Independence Day in North Macedonia.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Grier, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Milena Wälde and Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

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